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The Same Word, Three Meanings, One Filter

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A blacklist built across five languages runs into a problem that's easy to miss until it actually happens: the same word doesn't mean the same thing everywhere. Not close. Sometimes it means the opposite.

Take the word "mal." In Turkish, it's a slang insult, roughly "idiot" or "moron." In Portuguese and Spanish, it's a completely ordinary word, meaning "bad" or, in another common sense, "goods" or "property." A filter built with Turkish in mind flags it as an insult. Applied without adjustment to a Portuguese or Spanish-speaking user, it flags a sentence that's saying nothing more than "this item is bad quality."

Another example: "bunda." In Turkish, "bunda bir iş var" is an ordinary phrase meaning something like "there's something going on here," completely neutral. In Portuguese, the same string reads as harassment, close to slang or an insult depending on context. Same characters, same blacklist entry if you're not careful, two entirely different risk levels depending on which language the person typing it actually speaks.

I found both of these myself, while going through cases, not because a user complained or because a message got flagged and someone pushed back. Nobody had to tell me. It surfaced from just sitting with the data long enough to notice a pattern didn't hold across languages the way I'd assumed it would when I first built the entry.

What I didn't do was add a fix to the files right away. I took a note instead. Both of these sit in a gray zone, and gray zones are exactly the kind of thing that punishes a fast, confident change more than it rewards one. Adding a hard exception before I fully understood how the word actually gets used across contexts risked trading one blind spot for another, just a differently shaped one. So the decision was to flag it for closer, more careful review rather than resolve it on the spot.

No system covers every case, and building one across five languages doesn't change that; if anything it multiplies the number of places something like this can hide. That's not an argument against building the system. It's the reason a human has to keep sitting behind it, reading the cases a filter can't actually tell apart on its own.

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